Research-backed speech practice for Australia's Thriving Kids families

An opportunity brief from SpeechLP · November 2026

Australia is changing how it supports young children with developmental delay. SpeechLP, an iPhone and iPad app with web-based practice games, built by practising speech-language pathologists, can help families practise speech sounds between sessions, and we want to strengthen its evidence with Australian research partners.

The opportunity: Thriving Kids

From 1 October 2026, children aged 8 and under with developmental delay or autism and low to moderate support needs began accessing support through **Thriving Kids**, a new program outside the NDIS. It will be fully rolled out by 1 January 2028.[1]

≤ 8	$4B	2028
years of age	over 5 years, jointly committed[1]	full national rollout

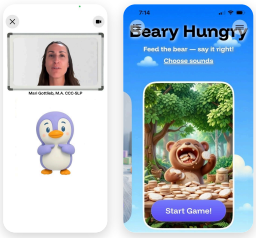
- **No formal diagnosis needed.** Eligibility is based on a functional assessment of the child's needs.[2]
- **Speech pathology is a targeted support,** delivered as group or one-on-one allied health services after a light-touch needs assessment.[2]
- **Entry points include online directories** and Thriving Kids-aligned health professionals.[3]
- **Not an individual funding package.** Supports are delivered through services, not portable funding.[4]

Why home practice matters here

Speech sound disorders are common in early childhood and are linked to later literacy difficulties. Progress depends on frequent practice, but therapy time is limited and home practice is rarely measured. Much of the research on intervention intensity and parent involvement comes from Australian researchers, including McLeod, Baker, Sugden, and Williams. With targeted supports in place of individual funding packages, structured home practice between sessions could play a larger role.

What SpeechLP offers

- **Age-based screeners** for ages 3–9 (about 15 words each), sampling sounds in initial, medial, and final positions.
- **Video lessons** in which two certified SLPs model each sound and the child practises it.
- **Speaking games** on iPhone, iPad, or the web, drawing on 1,000+ words across all 24 English consonants, with a spoken model of every word.
- **Automated speech recognition feedback** on every word; SpeechLP does not store children's audio on its servers.
- **SpeechTherapist.app** lets clinicians invite a caregiver, assign home practice, and track accuracy by sound.



SLP-led video lessons and speaking games, with practice data shared with the child's clinician.

Evidence so far, and what we are building

In a retrospective study of 101 returning children, app-scored accuracy on the same sounds rose from 69.4% to 74.9% across two months (+5.5 percentage points, 95% CI 0.4 to 10.4).[5] The scoring is not yet validated against SLP ratings and there was no comparison group, so this is a starting point, not proof of effectiveness. Our next study validates the app's scoring against several SLP raters, and its results will guide fine-tuning of our speech recognition model.

What Australia would need

- **Australian English adaptation** of word lists and speech recognition, which an Australian validation study would test directly.
- **Compliance with the Privacy Act 1988** and Australian Privacy Principles.
- **Fit with Thriving Kids pathways**, such as listing in provider directories and use by aligned speech pathologists.

Please note: SpeechLP is not currently affiliated with, endorsed by, or funded through Thriving Kids or the NDIS. This brief describes a potential fit, which we would explore with Australian partners.

We are looking for Australian university researchers, speech pathology practices, and Thriving Kids providers interested in a pilot or validation study in Australian English.

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Sources. 1. NDIS, "Thriving Kids" (ndis.gov.au/news/11085-thriving-kids). 2. Raising Children Network, "Thriving Kids support: your questions answered" (raisingchildren.net.au). 3. ABC News, "Model revealed for Thriving Kids," 3 February 2026. 4. NSW Department of Communities and Justice, "Thriving Kids" (dcj.nsw.gov.au). 5. Silver, S., Fox, A., Gottlieb, M., Siu, M., & Ndungu, J. (2026). *Children's articulation practice in SpeechLP across two months* [Preprint]. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23932485. Program details current as of November 2026 and may change; check state and territory pages for local arrangements.